

Dyeing poison frog

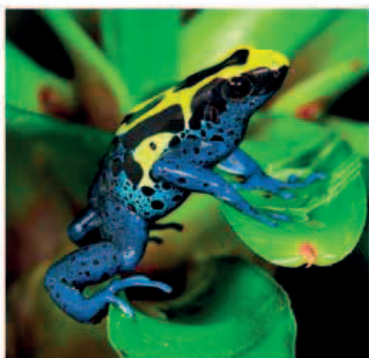
Dendrobates tinctorius

Dyeing poison frogs live on or near the forest floor and are mostly active by day. Males set up breeding territories and call for females, which may fight to win courtship rights. The winning female initiates mating by stroking the male's snout with her back feet. Six eggs are laid on a leaf and the male keeps them moist. The tadpoles hatch after about 14 days and both parents carry them on their backs to a bromeliad pool.

▷ COLOR VARIETIES

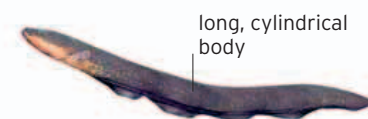
This pattern is typical of the species, with blue legs and belly, and broad yellow and black stripes on the back. Many other varieties exist using the same colors in different proportions.

- ↔ 1–2 in (3–5 cm)
- 📅 February, March
- ⊗ Common
- 🐜 Ants, termites, spiders
- 🏠 🌿
- 📍 NE. South America



Electric eel

Electrophorus electricus

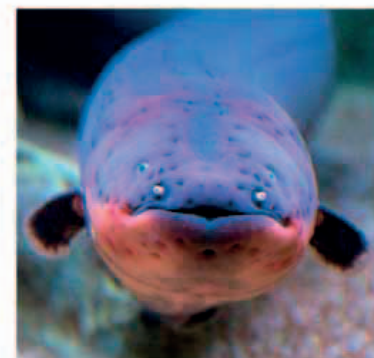


The electric eel is one of the largest freshwater fish in South America. It uses weak electrical pulses to find its way around and locate food in murky inland waters, such as rivers and ponds. It also produces larger electric shocks of around 600 volts that can kill other fish and even stun a human. The pulses are generated by organs of electrogenesis, which have about 5,000 to 6,000 modified muscle cells called electroplaques, running along almost the entire length of the fish's body.

▷ DECEPTIVE APPEARANCE

Although it looks like an eel, the electric eel is a type of knifefish that shares a common ancestor with catfish.

- ↔ 7–8 ft (2–2.5 m)
- ⚖️ 44 lb (20 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish, shrimp, crabs
- 🏠 🌊
- 📍 N. South America



Leaf-cutter ant

Atta cephalotes

Leaf-cutter ants live in extensive underground nests, with each colony consisting of millions of individuals. To feed the colony, small worker ants called "minimas" tend a fungus that grows on a mulch of cut leaves. This fungus can only survive inside the ants' nest, and needs their help to propagate. The pieces of leaf are cut and carried back to the nest by medium-sized "media" workers. The largest workers are called "maximas;"

they act as soldiers and guard the colony against intruders. The colony's single queen lays thousands of eggs every day.

▽ HARD AT WORK

A media worker can carry 50 times its own body weight. Leaf-cutters are also known as "parasol" ants because of the way they hold the leaves.

- ↔ 1/16–3/4 in (2–22 mm)
- ⊗ Common
- 🍄 Fungus
- 🏠 🌿



Central
America to N.
South America

